

education ISLAMIC SCHOOLS

With the launch of progressive schools in Mumbai, Muslim parents no longer have to choose between traditional Islamic values and a contemporary English learning

■ By Renu Ojha

A for Allah, B for Bismillah and C for Cave of Hira—where Prophet Mohammad received divine revelations. Dressed in the traditional skull cap and a crisp, white kurta-pyjama, four-year-old Mohammed Shaikh heads for school every morning. His destination? Not a madrasa, but a new age Muslim school. Al Jamiatul Fikriya Islamic English School (AJFIES), the first of 16 such schools set up in Mumbai since 1998. These schools embrace contemporary education, but not everything that comes along with it.

"The choice was between giving him the best English education and taking him away from his Islamic roots. Or sending him to a madrasa and depriving him of the global opportunities in life. So I thought why not have both?", says Sohail Shaikh, 40-year-old businessman and founder-principal of AJFIES. He started the school with just his son, but it has now expanded to 500 students. He is not alone. Twenty-five such schools have cropped up all over Maharashtra with the schools in Mumbai alone educating around 6,400 students, preparing a new breed of global Muslims who want to take on the West on their own terms.

Like nine-year-old Safwan Mirza, who studies at AJFIES, "When we grow up, we will go to America and teach them what true Islam is. We will tell the world that Islam is a religion of love and peace, and not violence and terror. Just like all dhoti-clad men are not Gandhi, all men sporting a beard and cap are not terrorists." Strong words for a nine-year-old, but reflective of how schools hope to overcome deep-rooted suspicions of traditional Islam.

What makes these schools stand out is the innovative syllabus, where Islamic references are used to impart an education in English. So even though the uniform here is conservative—*hijab* (veil) for girls from Class V onwards—some of these institutions do not even hesitate in touching upon sex education.



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THE RIGHT MIX 6,400 children are studying in 16 schools that have come up in Muslim-dominated areas.

ALL ON BOARD These schools are affiliated to major boards like the Maharashtra state board and CBSE.

ANYTHING GOES Issues from homosexuality to women's rights are discussed, but theories are interpreted from an Islamic point of view.

TRADITIONAL ATTIRE Boys wear the skull-cap with kurta pyjama, and girls have to wear a veil from Class V onwards.

Everything is discussed—homosexuality, marriage, divorce and women's rights—but debates are sprinkled with quotes from the Quran. The extent, however, to which schools conform to western standards varies. In some schools, academic theories that contradict Islam are either omitted or interpreted in line with Quranic beliefs. Darwin's theory of evolution, for example, which states that man has evolved from monkeys, is omitted by some while others teach it insisting that Allah is the creator.

Located around Konkan, Nashik, Pune, Aurangabad and Mumbai, these schools are fast changing the way young Muslims study, and are helping them be-